Final Portfolio and Reflection

Henry Shires

Eulogy

As we all have witnessed throughout our years knowing him, our beloved Henry was never far from reach. His kind and wise presence filled up the room every time we gathered as a family. His devoted heart to his wife and children was never shadowed by anything, his light gleaming in all aspects of his life. Even in his career, he never once hesitated to do what was right for his employees and fellow executives, even when temptation said to go another way. His mind was never motivated by riches and fame, only how his impact affected the ones close to him. The way Henry truly loved people was unique in a way and will be missed by all who had the pleasure to meet him.

My communication habits and processes

When beginning a piece, I first brainstorm ideas by comparing the requirements of the piece with subjects I am passionate about (technology, data, architecture, music, etc.). I am better equipped to capture my thoughts and effectively present them on paper by establishing an emotional connection to my piece. I then try to find a specific topic to write about by either speaking aloud or writing down my thoughts. This process results in keywords I can utilize to create a topic sentence or web search for completing my thesis and main idea.

I start drafting by outlining the entire piece, from the introduction and thesis to evidence/body paragraphs, and finally, the conclusion. I add concise bullet points and headings to remember the goal of each section of the piece without wasting time on the details. By planning the foundation of my piece, I can visualize what each section will focus on before I begin writing substance.

As a beginner, my original techniques for drafting consisted of making the first draft extraordinary and as perfect as possible, but this process became time-consuming and wasteful. I quickly learned the term rough draft is said for a reason: the first few iterations of a piece should be *rough* or barebones, containing holes and missing parts. The goal is to record initial ideas and perfect them with new iterations of a piece. Now, when I finish a rough draft, I enjoy finding the abundance of places to improve in my pieces, such as fixing repeated word choices, phrasing,

And content Improvements. The thesaurus and Ctrl + F soon became my two best friends during this process.

My communication skills

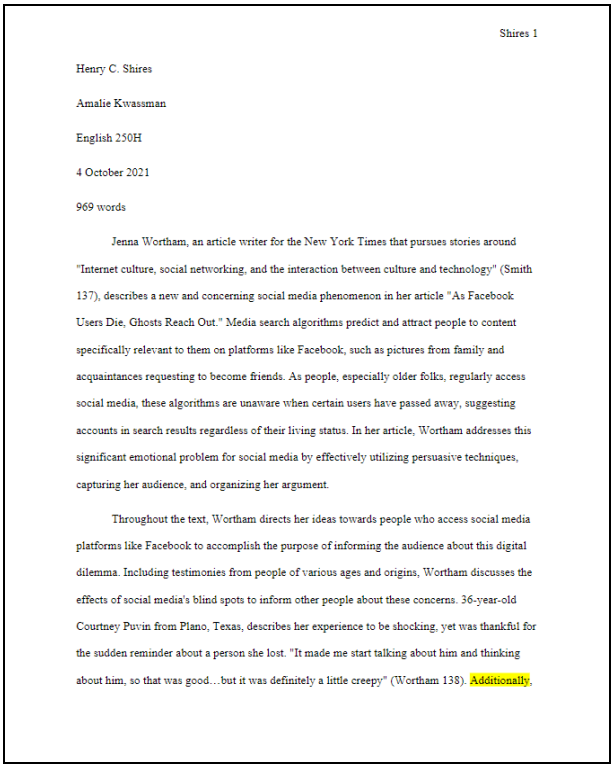
I find myself to have strengths, mostly in writing and electronic communication. I can determine how to phrase a thought correctly and effectively with very little time required in writing. I naturally use transitional phrases, find adequate synonyms for common words (given a thesaurus occasionally), and write bold, passionate sentences that captivate my audience. Although it may take multiple iterations of a draft, I will achieve beyond surface-level substance in my creativity or argument evidence (depending on the piece) and correctly organize my piece to match a common outline of my type of written work. My style also tends to be technical and profound, yet creative and unique, items that tend to match my character.

When it comes to electronic communication, I feel especially strong in this area. I have many years of experience creating digital works from tinkering in my free time and computer classes in high school. To start, I have a website and LinkedIn page to showcase my high school and college projects/resume online. I use these to communicate my skills to employers to land a solid career path for myself. Additionally, this website features a few of my media creations, such as short films and video presentations. I have films on recording my adventures and even one on explaining the fundamentals of a computer. I can confidently create a visually-appealing presentation of any digital medium that captures my audience and effectively delivers information.

Bringing in college credit from multiple English classes in high school, I've felt well prepared to enter language arts at Iowa State. However, I have also noticed areas where I continue to improve as a communicator. I continue to understand the importance of seeking feedback from my peers, as multiple pairs of eyes reviewing an idea leads to better results, accuracy, and clarity. I also need further practice with oral communication, as my ideas are sometimes unclear or fragmented when I present them. By working harder to attain the process of preparing a presentation or written work, I can improve my ability to effectively communicate ideas in my work and find new things to learn.

Written communication skills

My written communication skills are most exemplified through my rhetorical analysis. The assignment required the creation of a rhetorical argument about a text's use of rhetorical strategies and why or why not these strategies were effectively implemented. I chose to analyze a New York Times article by journalist Jenna Wortham about the persistence of accounts on social media belonging to users who have died. For the thesis of my analysis, I claimed "Wortham addresses this significant emotional problem for social media by effectively utilizing persuasive techniques, capturing her audience, and organizing her argument."



Shires 1

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969 words

Jenna Wortham, an article writer for the New York Times that pursues stories around "Internet culture, social networking, and the interaction between culture and technology" (Smith 137), describes a new and concerning social media phenomenon in her article "As Facebook Users Die, Ghosts Reach Out." Media search algorithms predict and attract people to content specifically relevant to them on platforms like Facebook, such as pictures from family and acquaintances requesting to become friends. As people, especially older folks, regularly access social media, these algorithms are unaware when certain users have passed away, suggesting accounts in search results regardless of their living status. In her article, Wortham addresses this significant emotional problem for social media by effectively utilizing persuasive techniques, capturing her audience, and organizing her argument.

Throughout the text, Wortham directs her ideas towards people who access social media platforms like Facebook to accomplish the purpose of informing the audience about this digital dilemma. Including testimonies from people of various ages and origins, Wortham discusses the effects of social media's blind spots to inform other people about these concerns. 36-year-old Courtney Puvin from Plano, Texas, describes her experience to be shocking, yet was thankful for the sudden reminder about a person she lost. "It made me start talking about him and thinking about him, so that was good…but it was definitely a little creepy" (Wortham 138). Additionally,

Then, address these questions: (2 paragraphs total/You can go over the paragraph limit if necessary) (Make sure to have transition phrases/breaking up paragraphs)

- Why did you choose this piece as an example of your best work?
- How did you interest your audience and direct their attention to your important points?
- How did you use feedback to create this work?
- What do you believe the piece/s demonstrate about you as a written communicator?
- How does this work connect with other work you did in this class or other classes?

As part of your discussion, provide a brief analysis that uses a specific example from your piece to explore your initial reflection in more depth.

"To capture a relevant audience, Wortham creates a phenomenal argument to accomplish her purpose of informing the public about addressing the reality of death and its relation to digital networks. She utilizes argument development such as pathos, ethos, and logos to strengthen her argument with emotional connection, logic, and credibility. Finally, she wisely organizes her argument and reasoning to inform her audience of the seemingly subtle flaw in social networks that may unintentionally harm, and in rare cases delight, many lives."

Overall, it's important to

Oral, visual, and electronic communication skills



My oral, visual, and electronic communication skills are most exemplified through my multimodal design. The assignment required creating a multimodal design that utilizes deliberate design and rhetorical choices to make an effective argument on the subject of death. I chose to produce a short film presenting the severity of the terrorist attacks of 9/11. My film gave a snapshot of the visual horror from that day in history to an audience born after 9/11 or too young to remember the day. I seized the common phrase "a picture is worth a thousand words" when making this film, as the scenes are nearly all pictures and few words to emphasize the visual argument the scenes portray. The tragedy and horror of the event pierce through the darker colors, somber soundtrack, and jarring statistics.

I selected this piece as my best work due to its uniqueness from my other works during the semester. No other students in my section presented a film for this

assignment and nearly everyone made simple slideshows (including me) to present their work at some point in the semester. Therefore, I felt this piece was the best representation of my electronic work that encapsulated the oral and visual communication areas.
Then, address these questions: **(2 paragraphs total/You can go over the paragraph limit if necessary)(include transition phrases/break up paragraphs)**

- How did you interest your audience and direct their attention to your important points?
- How did you use feedback to create this work?
- What do you believe the piece/s demonstrate about you as an oral, visual, or electronic communicator?
- How does this work connect with other work you did in this class or other classes?

As part of your discussion, provide a brief analysis that uses a specific example from your piece to explore your initial reflection in more depth.

“Thank you for your hard work, thank you for making the nation proud, and may God bless America” - President George W. Bush.



As I’ve had experience making films before, I used a lot of the same techniques I’m familiar with in writing, developing, and editing. The challenging part of this piece involved actually finding images, clips, and audio that I had permission to use and making sure I properly cited them all. I ended up with quite a handful of media sources, so I quickly learned I need to record each source as I find one rather than trying to search back for all of them at the end. In all of my films, I also limit myself to the maximum duration of my soundtrack to get my points communicated. This gave me a challenge to still effectively communicate my argument while

remaining concise. Overall I enjoyed making my creative vision come to life on screen and challenging myself to use alternate techniques of argument rather than writing another essay.

Final Reflection

This final section will reflect on how you can continue your development as a communicator and lifelong learner.
Write this Final Reflection as a letter addressed to me. Use paragraphs/transition phrases.

Vision and Life Plans(At least 1 paragraph)

You should begin by discussing your vision for the future. What are your most important goals for the next five years? What do you aspire to do? Who do you want to be? What are the important steps along the way?

Summary of Skills (at least 1 paragraph)

Next, you will consider the most important communication habits, processes, and skills you will need to achieve these goals and life plans? Address these issues:

- What are communication strengths? How can you build on them?
- How can you improve your communication habits and processes?
- Which aspects of your written, oral, visual, and electronic communication skills will it be most important to continue to develop?

Then, write at least a paragraph about what new things you have learned about death(at least three new things and reference SPECIFIC assignments, class activities, readings, etc.)

Goals and Action Steps

Then, you should set specific learning goals for the future. **What are 2-4 specific goals you are willing to commit to, t**hat will move you closer to your ideal career and life vision? Under each goal, consider the action you will take to help you make progress in reaching your goal. Action steps are very specific, concrete things you will do to achieve your goals. Try thinking in terms of “SMART goals” (specific, measurable, achievable, realistic, timely).

SUGGESTED OUTLINE (2-4 goals)
Goal: I will practice this habit, or improve in this area, or achieve this result.
Action: I will take these actions by this date or within this time frame.
Action: I will seek help, support, or resources in these areas.

Milestone: I will know that what I'm doing is working when I achieve this specific indicator of progress and success.

Conclusion

As you finish your reflection, you should take a moment to appreciate all the hard work you've put into this course and the resilience you've shown in completing the course online during the pandemic. **You might write about the most challenging part of your experience and how you were able to overcome it. You might reflect on the lessons you learned about yourself and your ability to learn and adapt. You might consider how it has helped reveal what's really important to you or what you most want to be able to do moving forward.**